to Rakesh Dixit. The politician was willing to work with the Indian agency to end the political oppression in Bangladesh and Ershad's rule.

'This powerful politician codenamed Amir told us that the only way to neutralise Ershad and counter the challenge of the ISI and CIA in the same breath was to confront them with a mass public movement. I agreed with his assessment. We always wanted a better relationship with our neighbouring country and tolerated Ershad as long as he remained neutral. But I believed he had been nurturing seeds of hatred against India since the coup and our conscious decision was to stop him by any means/ said Patwardhan, recalling the frantic debates between the R&AW spies on splitting Ershad's support base.

The R&AW analysts in Dhaka prepared an exhaustive handwritten assessment for Operation Farewell. In July 1990, four intelligence officers were given all the necessary resources including funds to execute the operation. The diplomats were kept far away from the espionage team. Ismail's and Amir's networks were tasked to act as listening posts for the R&AW and they too were given unparalleled access to funds and other resources. Although the CIA supported the Ershad government, its intelligence assessments were realistic about the dictator's future. An American intelligence memo candidly admitted that Ershad had no political legitimacy and even his so-called political front lacked popular public support. The CIA worried that the Bangladesh military might not follow Ershad's dictates in dealing with lawlessness due to a possible public uprising.

In late August that year, an expected scenario unfolded in Dhaka and other major cities. Political parties, student unions and various other social organisations indirectly supported by